said of this time, ‘I experienced an internal bitterness, and from the lack of spiritual provision for my last journey, my soul was seized with exceeding sorrow.’ This had been a tumultuous time for Akbar for he had lost three members of his foster family in a particularly violent way. The old order had scattered, their familiar love now gone. For Akbar it would now be a time of new alliances and unexpected friendships.

These years were also a time of gradual but momentous changes in the very fabric of the Mughal court. Possibly as early as 1556, an erudite Brahmin named Mahesh Das from a village near Kalpi was introduced to Akbar’s court. Badauni, who was often tormented about what he felt was the erosion of Islamic beliefs from Akbar’s heart, tried to understand the genesis of this failing. ‘The emperor from his youth up had shown a special predilection and inclination for the society of religious sects such as brahmans and musicians and other kinds of Hindus,’ he wrote, before going on to focus his wrath on one particular Brahmin. ‘Accordingly at the beginning of his reign a certain brahman musician, Gadain Brhmaindas by name, whose whole business was perpetually to praise the Hindus and who [was] possessed of a considerable amount of capacity and genius, came to court. By means of conversing with the emperor and taking advantage of the idiosyncrasies of his disposition, he crept day by day more into favour until he attained to high rank, and was honoured with the distinction of becoming the emperor’s confidant.’ This man, acknowledged even by the critical Badauni as having innate genius, would later gain fame at Akbar’s court under the name Bir-Bar (renowned warrior) or Birbal.

Of the much reviled musicians that Badauni regretted came to the court there was one, in particular, whose name and immortal, yearning music would come to be associated forever with Akbar. In 1562, Akbar heard of the talent of one Tansen Kalavant Gwaliyari, singer at the court of Raja Ramachandra of Baghela. This raja was exceedingly fond of his musician, to whom it was said he once gave one crore gold pieces after a particularly mesmerizing raag. Tansen, too, Badauni noted, did not want to leave the court of Ramachandra but the young Padshah was no longer a man whose summons could be ignored. There is the possibility that this tussle over Tansen may not have been entirely due to musical yearning. As Akbar began to expand his influence deeper into the hinterland, claiming for himself the greatest gem of the Baghela court was also an exercise in